

# Rhinoceroses

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|---------|----------------|
| PHYLUM  | Chordata       |
| CLASS   | Mammalia       |
| ORDER   | Perissodactyla |
| FAMILY  | Rhinocerotidae |
| SPECIES | 5              |

Among the largest of terrestrial mammals, rhinoceroses have a thick skin that folds in places so it resembles a suit of armor. They live in the savannas of Africa, and in the tropical and subtropical forests and swampy grasslands of Asia. Although rhinoceroses are often considered

aggressive—they will charge to scare off an intruder—they are generally timid. All 5 species are endangered, 3 of them critically so. All species require a large daily intake of food (either grass or stems, branches, and leaves) to support their massive body.

## Anatomy

Rhinoceroses are large, heavily built animals—the white rhino may weigh up to 2½ tons (2.3 tonnes). The species found in Asia support their bulky frame with thick legs, but African species have surprisingly slim legs and are capable of running at speeds of up to 28 mph (45 kph). Each foot has 3 toes, each with a hoof. The large head features one or 2 horns (depending on species) on the snout. Instead of a bony core (as in the horns of cattle and their relatives, for example), the horns are composed entirely of keratin—a tough protein also found in hair and nails—and the horn perches on a roughened area of the skull (rather than being “rooted” in the skull). Rhinoceroses also have skin up to ¾ in (2 cm) thick, and body hair is usually inconspicuous (although all species have a tail tuft and ear fringes). Asian rhinoceroses have heavily folded skin, giving the appearance of plates of armor.

Of all the senses, smell is the strongest, although mobile, tubular ears provide good hearing. The eyes, however, are small, and rhinoceroses have poor vision.

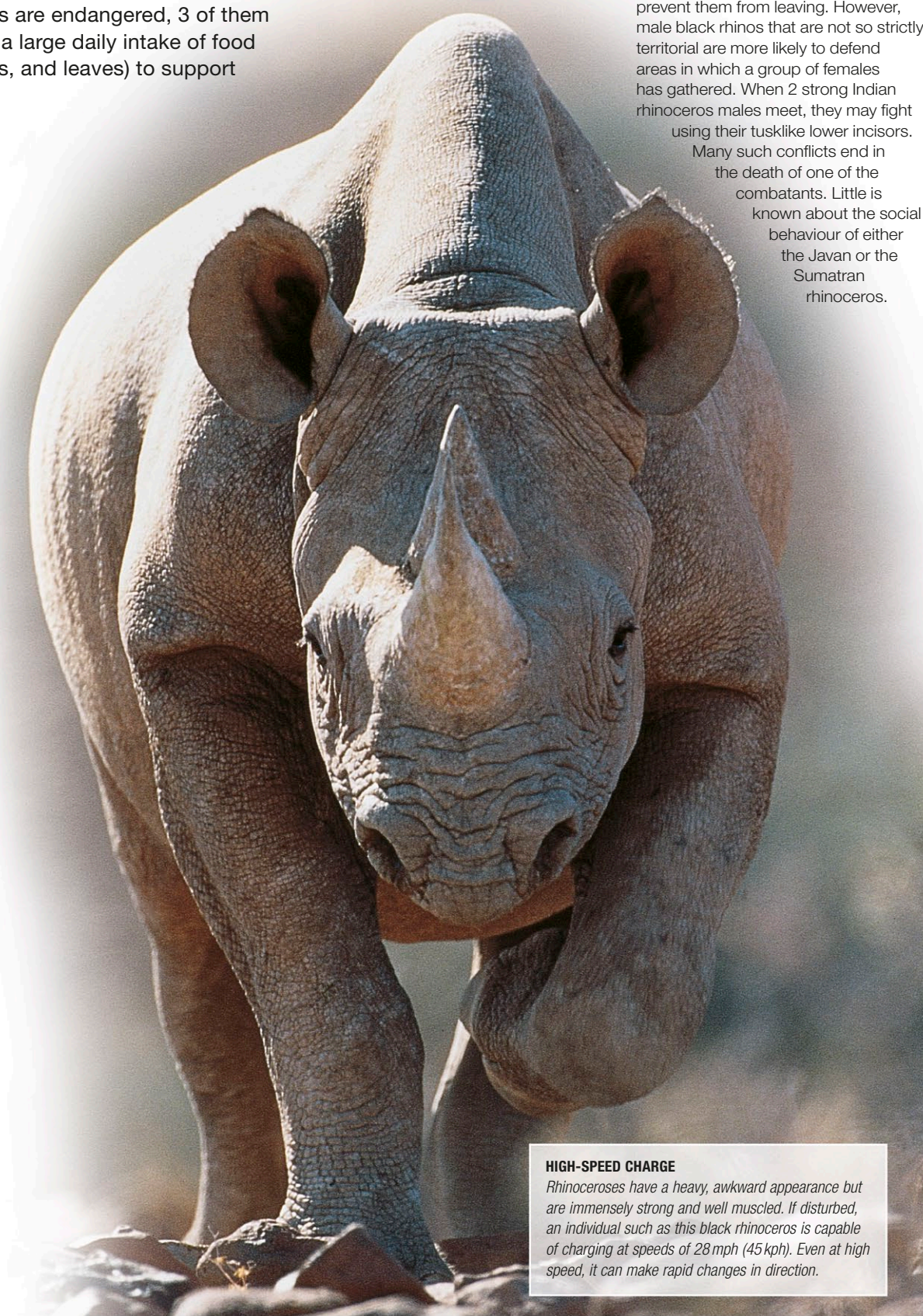
## CONSERVATION

The entire rhino family is listed by CITES, mainly because rhino horn is worth more than its weight in gold. In the Far East, it is powdered and used in medicine, while in Yemen, it is carved to make dagger handles. Both practices are now illegal, although an undercover trade still goes on. In Africa alone, over 1,300 rhinoceroses were killed in 2015. Conservation measures have allowed numbers of southern white rhinoceros and black rhinoceros to increase. However, unless poaching is controlled and habitat loss halted, the future for these animals remains bleak.

## Social systems

Although rhinoceroses are mostly solitary, subadults may travel in pairs, female white rhinoceroses sometimes form groups, and Indian rhinoceroses will share a bathing pond without aggression. Grazing species (white, Indian) range more widely than browsing species (black, Sumatran,

and Javan). Dominant male white rhinoceroses patrol their home range, marking its boundaries by spraying urine and creating dung piles. Weaker males share the ranges of stronger males, but do not attempt to mate. The white and Indian rhinos also employ a “strong” male / “weak” male system. Strong males actively herd receptive females into their territories, and then prevent them from leaving. However, male black rhinos that are not so strictly territorial are more likely to defend areas in which a group of females has gathered. When 2 strong Indian rhinoceros males meet, they may fight using their tusklike lower incisors. Many such conflicts end in the death of one of the combatants. Little is known about the social behaviour of either the Javan or the Sumatran rhinoceros.



## HIGH-SPEED CHARGE

Rhinoceroses have a heavy, awkward appearance but are immensely strong and well muscled. If disturbed, an individual such as this black rhinoceros is capable of charging at speeds of 28 mph (45 kph). Even at high speed, it can make rapid changes in direction.